MISSING THE MIDDLE CLASS



Photographs by BANDEEP SINGH

Once an engine of India's economic growth, now reeling from the pandemic, India's middle classes find little comfort in Budget 2022

By SHWWETA PUNJ

Nirmala Sitharaman is as middle class as it gets in India. She did her schooling in Chennai and Tiruchirappalli before getting a Bachelor's degree in economics from the Seethalakshmi Ramaswami College in Tamil Nadu and then pursuing a master's degree at JNU. Notwithstanding her meteoric rise from BJP spokesperson to handling major portfolios in the Modi government, she is seen as part of the larger fold of India's middle class—now estimated to be 380 million-strong, or close to a fourth of India's total population. For many years now, the booming middle class has been seen as the symbol of India's phenomenal economic rise since the 1991 economic reforms. Not anymore.

As the Covid-19 pandemic continues into its third year, India's middle class has taken an especially hard hit, with an estimate by the US-based Pew Research Center suggesting this demographic shrank by 32 million in 2020. Pew also says the number of poor in India is estimated to have more than doubled post the pandemic, and the middle class cut by a third. Many surveys and studies testify to the economic pain the middle class is going through as a result of the ongoing pandemic. According to Pew, the number of Indians who are poor—with incomes of $2 (Rs 150), or less per day—is estimated to have increased by 75 million because of the Covid-19 recession, accounting for nearly 60 per cent of the global increase in poverty

Although 'middle class' is a group with many definitions—a broad band of households with incomes anywhere from Rs 10 lakh to Rs 1 crore per annum—the scars of the pandemic are visible wherever one looks. Take Sanjeev Shukla